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W E D N E S D A Y , J A N U A R Y 2 8 , 2 0 2 6

‘Stuck’ patients strain hospitals

Guardians to make decisions in short supply

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

With a surge of flu cases straining emergency departments, Massachusetts hospitals once again are struggling to find available beds in part because of a longstanding problem: high numbers of patients who can’t be discharged because they are not able to make medical decisions for themselves.

Patients who have no one — neither friend nor family member — to take responsibility for their care require state-appointed guardians to make decisions for them. But the process of obtaining a guardian can be long and cumbersome, leaving patients to wait, sometimes for months, in area hospitals, taking up beds sorely needed for sicker people coming into the ER, such as now when the Massachusetts health department says there is a “very high” level of flu illnesses.

At Cambridge Health Alliance’s three hospitals, the number of such “stuck” patient days

GUARDIANS, Page A6

Post puts finger on Mass. tech malaise

KARA MILLER
COMMENTARY

The post appeared on X just after New Year’s, in those quiet days before schools restarted and the first full workweek began.

But it started a firestorm, one that Brian Halligan — a prominent tech investor and co-founder of Cambridge-based software company HubSpot — could hardly have anticipated.

“I’m starting to worry about Massachusetts,” Halligan posted on Jan. 2. And then came his list of particulars.

“Biotech is way off from a few years ago,” he noted, along with the fact that just one of Forbes’s AI 50 — a list of the hottest, privately held artificial intelligence companies — is based in Massachusetts. More than 30 are in California, such as OpenAI and Anthropic, and a second Boston-area company — OpenEvidence — recently decamped to Miami, leaving only one: AI music firm Suno.

Halligan continued: Federal funding cuts have been painful

INNOVATION, Page A6

‘I WANT MY MOM’

5-year-old feels pain of sudden separation after parent picked up by ICE in Maine



FINN GOMEZ FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Keyli Camila Espin Vaca was sent to stay with her uncle and aunt while her mother was taken to Massachusetts.

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio
GLOBE STAFF

BIDDEFORD, Maine — Five-year-old Keyli Camila Espin Vaca expected her mother to come pick her up after school on Friday, just as she always did.

But her mother never came.

Mayra Vaca Latacunga, 25, had dropped Camila off at the Biddeford Primary School that morning, then went to get groceries. Soon after, ICE agents stopped her car and requested her documentation, her brother said. She didn’t have it. The agents handcuffed her and transferred her to Massachusetts.

Vaca Latacunga, a single mother from Ecuador, was Camila’s sole caretaker. On Friday, school officials escorted the kindergartner to her Uncle Javier’s house. She stayed there for several days, pleading for her mom.

“*Quiero mi mamá, tío,*” Camila said in Spanish on

‘You have a 5-year-old — you can’t even imagine what’s going on in her head right now.’

SUPERINTENDENT
JEREMY RAY,
Biddeford, Maine, schools

Sunday. “*Yo quiero estar con mi mamá.*”

“I want my mom, uncle . . . I want to be with my mom.”

Camila is among a growing number of children who have been left without a parent as the Trump administration carries out a major immigration enforcement effort in Maine, according to local officials. “Operation Catch of the Day,” as the Department of Homeland Security calls it, is meant to arrest around 1,400 people. They have arrested more than 200 so far, DHS Assistant Secretary Tricia McLaughlin said in a statement Monday to the Globe.

“Some of the arrests of the worst of the worst from the first day of operations include criminal illegal aliens charged and convicted of horrific crimes, including aggravated assault, false imprisonment, and endangering the welfare of a child,” McLaughlin said.

MOTHER, Page A7

Trump vows ‘honest investigation’ into Minn. killing

Continues to blame victim for carrying gun

By Hamed Aleaziz, Ernesto Londoño,
David E. Sanger, and Mitch Smith
NEW YORK TIMES

President Trump on Tuesday promised a “very honorable and honest investigation” into the killing of Alex Pretti by federal agents in Minneapolis, even as he continued to blame Pretti for carrying a legally permitted gun that was seized from him before he was fatally shot.

“You can’t walk in with guns,” Trump told reporters as he left the White House for a speech in Iowa. “You can’t do that,” he added, before calling Pretti’s death “a very unfortunate incident.”

Trump and his top aides have faced sharp criticism since the killing on Saturday of Pretti, a nurse at a Veterans Affairs hospital, both for the actions of the agents and for officials’ descriptions of Pretti. Stephen Miller, Trump’s deputy chief of staff, described Pretti as an “assassin” — a characterization Trump said Tuesday that he disagreed with.

The outcry over the killing of Pretti, 37, has spanned the political spectrum, putting pressure on the White House. On Monday, Trump dispatched his border czar, Tom Homan, to directly oversee the federal operation in Minnesota. As part of the shake-up, he also planned to pull out its director of on-the-ground enforcement, Gregory Bovino, according to two federal officials.

Homan met Tuesday with Minnesota Governor Tim Walz and Mayor Jacob Frey of Minneapolis, two Democrats who have been de-

MINNESOTA, Page A7



ADAM GRAY/ASSOCIATED PRESS

A man in handcuffs tried to avoid being detained by federal immigration agents in Minneapolis on Tuesday.

A technicolor dreamcoat for an amazing season



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

Ann Michael Maye sported a custom-made coat from a designer who used patches from her husband’s jersey.

Ann Michael Maye, wife of the famous QB, has made a name for herself in New England

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

It’s not every WAG — wife or girlfriend of a famous athlete — who gets the endorsement of the National Football League.

But soon after Ann Michael Maye posted a photo of herself wearing a fluffy white hat, red track pants, and bespoke puffer coat made from patches of her husband’s Patriots jersey, the NFL tweeted that the quarterback’s better half had “the AFC Championship fit ready” ahead of Sunday’s big game.

And after the Patriots beat the Denver Broncos, 10-7, many took to social media to hail Ann Michael, who’s been nicknamed both the First Lady of New England and the Queen of the North.

At 22, Maye is more girl-next-door than glamorous, more practical than posh — think of her as the polar opposite of, say, Victoria Beckham or Cardi B. She’s whisked her way into Pats fans’ hearts via the baking videos she shares on social media and simultaneously become a style inspiration

MAYE, Page A5

Cover story

Wednesday: Sunny, cold. High 24-29. Low 7-12.

Thursday: Sunny, cold. High 22-27. Low 4-9.

High tide: 6:14 a.m., 7 p.m. Sunrise: 7:02 Sunset: 4:53

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

Seven Haverhill police officers won’t be charged for restraining a man who died in the encounter. **B1.**

Some small area restaurants are using AI to take orders, with mixed results. **B5.**

Bill Belichick may have won six Super Bowls, but he won’t be a first-ballot Hall of Famer. **C1.**

The Michelin Guide recently recognized about 25 Boston restaurants. How are they doing now? **G1.**

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